

Values Clarification Exercise

FREE RESOURCE · COACHING

Values Clarification Exercise

A guided values clarification exercise — a 50-value card sort, a ranking process, and reflection questions for use in coaching sessions.

50-Value Card Sort

Ranking Process

Reflection Questions

Values Conflict Exploration

50

values

5

ranking steps

5

reflection questions

4

conflict prompts

HOW TO USE THIS EXERCISE

This works best with genuine time set aside — 15–20 minutes uninterrupted, not squeezed between other tasks. There are no right answers here; the value of the exercise comes entirely from being honest about what actually matters to you, not what you think should matter.

The 50-Value Card Sort

Read through every value below. In the ranking process on the next page, you'll narrow this list down in stages.

01
Achievement

02
Adventure

03
Authenticity

04
Autonomy

05
Balance

06
Beauty

07
Boldness

08
Calm

09
Career

10
Community

11
Compassion

12
Connection

13
Contribution

14
Courage

15
Creativity

16
Curiosity

17
Dependability

18
Discipline

19
Diversity

20
Empathy

21

22

23

24

25

Excellence	Fairness	Faith	Family	Financial Security
26 Freedom	27 Friendship	28 Fun	29 Growth	30 Harmony
31 Health	32 Honesty	33 Humour	34 Independence	35 Influence
36 Integrity	37 Justice	38 Kindness	39 Knowledge	40 Leadership
41 Loyalty	42 Meaningful Work	43 Openness	44 Optimism	45 Recognition
46 Respect	47 Responsibility	48 Security	49 Service	50 Wisdom

Ranking Process Guide

Work through these steps in order — resist the urge to jump straight to a top 5 without going through the narrowing stages.

- 1

Read through all 50 values

Go through the full list once and circle or mark every value that resonates at all — don't overthink this pass, go with your first reaction.
- 2

Narrow to your top 15

Look only at the values you marked. Cross out the ones that feel less essential when compared directly to the others.
- 3

Narrow to your top 8

This step is usually the hardest — you're now choosing between values you genuinely care about, not filtering out ones you don't.
- 4

Narrow to your top 5

At this stage, each remaining value should feel like something you'd defend, not just something you like.
- 5

Rank your top 5, 1 through 5

Rank 1 is the single value you would keep if you could only keep one — this is often the most revealing step in the whole exercise.

YOUR TOP 5 VALUES, RANKED

Rank	Value	Why This One
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		

Reflection Questions

Work through these for your #1 ranked value first — repeat for others if useful, but don't dilute the exercise by doing all five at once.

Why does this value matter to you? Where did it come from?

Consider a formative experience, a person, or a period in your life that shaped this.

When in your life have you felt most aligned with this value?

Name a specific moment or period, not a general sense of it.

When have you felt most compromised on this value? What happened?

On a scale of 1–10, how well does your current work and life actually reflect this value?

If this value were fully honoured in your life, what would look different?

Be concrete — a decision, a boundary, a daily habit, not just a general feeling.

Values Conflict Exploration

Core values often pull in different directions — naming the tension directly is usually more useful than pretending it isn't there.

Do any of your top 5 values conflict with each other in practice?

e.g. Security and Adventure, Family and Career, Independence and Connection. Describe the actual tension.

Which value do you tend to sacrifice first when under pressure, and what does that cost you?

Is there a value on your original list that conflicts with a choice you're currently making, or a role you're currently in?

What would it look like to honour both values more fully, rather than defaulting to one over the other?

This is often less about choosing and more about redesigning the situation itself.

A NOTE FOR COACHES

This exercise often surfaces more in the silence between questions than in the answers themselves — resist the urge to fill every pause, and let the client sit with a difficult ranking decision rather than rescuing them from it too quickly.